That helped, but it wasn’t enough. Arnow said that if I appeared on screen the way that God had made me, I would look out of proportion.

“Your shoulders are too big and your neck is too short for your head,” he insisted, not very tactfully, I thought.

There was a lot of foot shuffling and mumbling among the tailors, but no one, as I hoped, came forward and said: “His head looks okay to me.”

Everyone looked troubled. Then somebody thought of Jimmy Cagney, one of Warner Brothers’ biggest stars. “He’s got the same problem, a short neck,” the voice said.

Cagney, the wardrobe expert said, had solved his problem by going to a shirtmaker who had succeeded in creating the appearance of a longer neck and a bigger head by designing a special shirt collar for him.

Behind his neck, Cagney’s shirts had a normal collar band, but as it encircled his neck it became smaller and narrower, so by the time it reached his chest, there wasn’t any collar band at all. The tips of the collar just lay flat on his chest, revealing a few more inches of skin than would have been exposed by an ordinary collar.

“Get the name of Cagney’s shirtmaker,” someone said urgently.

This was accomplished and I was sent to have some shirts made with a Cagney collar. But when I came back to the studio the experts said my shoulders and chest still appeared to be a little too wide for my head.

Until then, I’d always worn narrow ties and shirts with small collars, whatever was in style at the time. To solve the problem, the wardrobe people instructed me to have all my shirts made with an extra-wide collar with near-horizontal lines and to use a wide Windsor knot when I tied my tie—anything, they said, to fill the gap between my lapels and reduce the appearance of the width of my shoulders.